

English SP

The Triumph of Dystopian Literature

What's behind the boom in dystopian fiction for young readers?

Cloze / gap-fill questions

TODAY'S lesson

10 Vocabulary items

1 Exam tip — cloze questions

4 Demo questions

6 Exam questions (15 marks)

Key vocabulary: match the meanings

1 authoritarian Line 4 I

2 oppressive Line 5 G

3 conform Line 45 H

4 conducive Line 22 C

5 trilogy Line 25 B

6 cliff-hanger Line 52 F

7 façade Line 93 J

8 utopia Line 93 A

9 didactic Line 140 D

10 extinction Line 117 E

A. an imagined perfect world, in which everything is good.

B. a set of three connected books, films or plays.

C. making something more likely to happen; helpful for.

D. written to teach a moral lesson.

E. the state of no longer existing; being completely destroyed.

F. an exciting ending that leaves readers unsure what happens next.

G. treating people in a harsh and controlling way.

H. to behave in the same way as everyone else; to follow a fixed standard.

I. demanding total obedience; allowing no personal choice.

J. an outward appearance that hides the truth.

Match the 10 words to the definitions — write the letter in the blank.

What helps you gain the mark?

Reminders for CLOZE (gap-fill) questions

1 Read the whole summary carefully

The summary is a PARAPHRASE — it uses different words. Example: the summary says “asked for more space”; the paragraph says “asked the principal for a bigger room”.
Find the paragraph first: the question names it (“Based on paragraph 2 ...”).

2 Use the words around the blank to find the word class

a / an + _____ = noun more _____ = adjective (comparative)
grew _____ = adverb (-ly) would _____ = verb (base form)
by + _____ = noun or -ing form

3 Hunt for the matching IDEA in the paragraph

Do not hunt for the summary’s words — hunt for the same meaning.
Read the whole sentence around the blank: “but”, “so”, “because” tell you how the idea is built.

4 Copy the EXACT word — then check the form

ONE word per blank; a fixed pair printed in the text counts as one answer.
Check the form: -s · -ed · -ing · -er · -ly — and check the spelling.

Then read your completed sentence again — does it make sense, and is it grammatical?

Cloze questions — 4 demos on one paragraph

(demo — a made-up paragraph, not from the examination paper)

DEMO PARAGRAPH — read it together first

Last year, our school library started a lunchtime reading club. At first, only eight students came, and the librarian, Ms Wong, lent them books from her own shelf. Then the club began posting short book reviews on the school's social media page, and the reviews spread quickly: by the end of the term, more than two hundred students had joined the club. Ms Wong has asked the principal for a bigger room, because the club is now the busiest place in the school. Some teachers worried that the club would distract students from their homework, but the library's records show that club members borrow twice as many books as other students.

EASIER 1 • ONE word

The librarian lent the first students books from her (i) _____ shelf.

(i) **own** 1 mark

EASIER 2 • ONE word

By the end of the term, more than two (i) _____ students had joined the club.

(i) **hundred** 1 mark

HARDER 1 • ONE word

The club grew (i) _____ after its book reviews appeared online.

(i) **quickly** 1 mark

HARDER 2 • TWO words

Some teachers worried that the club would (i) _____ students from their homework, but the library's records show that members (ii) _____ more books than other students.

(i) **distract** (ii) **borrow** 2 marks

1 word class → 2 read around the blank → 3 copy the exact word → 4 check the form

Read the paragraph — then write your answer

1. What does “it” (line 6) refer to?

dystopia

[1] Dystopia is an imaginary place or condition in which everything is bad, and in dystopian fiction, this has traditionally been characterized by an authoritarian government or some kind of oppressive control. For young readers, dystopia isn't a future to be averted; it is a version of what's already happening in the world they inhabit.

Evidence & explanation

Read backwards — find the noun before “it”

(1 mark • 88%)

Read the paragraph — then complete the summary

2. Based on paragraph 2, complete the text with ONE word in each blank. (5 marks)

Check the grammar — word form, plurals etc.

The novel *When You Reach Me* takes place in New York City (NYC) where (i) _____ grew up. In the 1970s, NYC had a higher (ii) _____, but children back then had more (iii) _____. In contrast, NYC today is (iv) _____ yet children are more (v) _____ by their parents. As a result, children don't walk the streets alone.

(i) Rebecca Stead

(ii) crime rate

(iii) freedom // autonomy // adventure

(iv) safer

(v) protected // controlled

[2] Rebecca Stead chose to set her children's novel *When You Reach Me* – winner of the 2010 Newbery Medal – in nineteen-seventies New York partly because that's where she grew up, but also because she wanted 'to show a world of kids with a great deal of autonomy.' Her characters, middle-class middle-school students, routinely

walk around the Upper West Side by themselves, a rare freedom in today's city, despite a significant drop in New York's crime rate since Stead's footloose youth. The world of our ~~covered-over~~ teens and preteens may be safer but it's also less conducive to adventure, and therefore to adventure stories.

Evidence & explanation

Watch the FORM, not just the word: comparative -er • past participle -ed

(5 marks • 91 / 78 / 74 / 59 / 45%)

Read the paragraph — then complete the synopsis

3. Based on paragraph 3, complete the book synopsis with ONE word in each blank. (6 marks)

Check the grammar — word form, plurals etc.

The Hunger Games is the (i) _____ book in a trilogy of novels written by Suzanne Collins. The story takes place some time in the (ii) _____. Two children from (iii) _____ district are forced to compete in the Hunger Games. The contest is held in an (iv) _____ and shown (v) _____. The sole survivor (vi) _____.

(i) first

(ii) future

(iii) each

(iv) outdoor arena

(v) on television // TV

(vi) wins // lives

25 [3] Perhaps that's why so many of them are reading *The Hunger Games*, a trilogy of novels by Suzanne Collins, which depicts a futuristic North America broken up into twelve districts. Every year, two children from each district are forced to fight to death in a
30 televised contest called the Hunger Games, which are held in a huge outdoor arena. The

35 winner of the contest is the last child left alive. The fervently awaited third installment in the trilogy, *Mockingjay*, will be published by Scholastic in August, and there are currently in print more than 2.3 million copies of the previous two books, *The Hunger Games* and *Catching Fire*.

Evidence & explanation

The third book is *Mockingjay* — so this one is ...?

(6 marks • 24 / 21 / 68 / 88 / 38 / 46%)

Read the paragraph — then write your answer

4. What does the simile “like a wicked strain of the flu” (lines 68–69) suggest about the book *The White Mountains*?

the interest in dystopian novels for young-adult readers spread very quickly // the book was infectious // it was popular / a big hit (among teens, among her classmates)

65 their behavior. *The White Mountains*, in which alien overlords install mind-control caps on the heads of all those over the age of thirteen, tore through my own sixth-grade classroom like a wicked strain of the flu. Depending on the

Evidence & explanation

What did the book do to her whole class?

(1 mark • 23%)

Read the paragraph — then write your answer

5. In paragraph 7, find a word which means “a major disaster”.

catastrophe // apocalypse

105 [7] The youth-centered versions of
dystopia part company with their adult
predecessors in some important respects. For
one thing, the grownup ones are grimmer. The
British academic Kay Sambell argues that ‘the
110 protagonist’s final defeat and failure is
absolutely crucial to the admonitory nature of
the classic adult dystopia.’ The adult dystopia
extrapolates from the present to show readers
how terrible things will become if our
115 deplorable behavior continues unchecked.
Because authors of children’s fiction are
‘reluctant to depict the extinction of hope
within their stories,’ Sambell writes, they
equivocate when it comes to delivering a moral.
120 Yes, our errors and delusions may lead to
catastrophe but if – as usually happens in
dystopian novels for children – a new, better
way of life can be assembled from the ruins,
would the **apocalypse** really be such a bad
125 thing?

Evidence & explanation

**Look for a NOUN — and do not
write “disaster”
(1 mark • 69%)**

Read the paragraph — then write your answer

6. What does “**this**” (line 139) refer to?

children not having control in the world // (children)
don't run the world

[9] Children, however, don't run the world, and teenagers, especially, feel the sting of this. Dystopian fiction may be the only genre written for children that's routinely less didactic than its adult counterpart. *The Hunger Games* could be taken as an indictment of reality TV, but it is not an argument. It operates like a fable or a myth, a story in which outlandish and extravagant figures and events serve as conduits for universal experiences.

Evidence & explanation

Read back to the subject of the paragraph
(1 mark • 18%)